THE GENERATIVE ETHIC

A structural framework for existence, goodness,
and the obligation of conscious agents

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Companion papers: AI Alignment · Political Significance · Extended Metaphysics

A Note on Language and Register

This framework is intended as a bridge across scientific, philosophical, religious, and secular worldviews. To serve that goal, it must be careful not to import the vocabulary of any single tradition unnecessarily.

The framework operates in three distinct registers, used deliberately:

Register	Key Terms	Purpose
Structural	generative / degenerative	Logical and scientific arguments; no moral loading
Directional	aligned / misaligned with generative emergence	Normative claims without presupposing intent
Moral	Good / Bad, Goodness / Badness	Reserved for discussions of conscious choice and ethical orientation

"Good" and "Bad" as capitalised terms are defined *within* the framework as the moral names for structural alignment and misalignment — technical terms with precise definitions, not pre-loaded moral categories. Readers from a scientific background should read "Good" as shorthand for "aligned with generative emergence."

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1. Core Claim

Reality emerges through the recursive interaction between two fundamental tendencies: **connection** and **separation**.

From this interaction arise: matter, life, intelligence, morality, culture, and potentially meaning itself.

Goodness, within this framework, is not static perfection. It is movement toward **richer forms of connectedness that preserve differentiation, adaptability, and future generative emergence**.

Human purpose is therefore: **conscious participation in the ongoing emergence of healthier forms of reality** — not toward final completion, but toward endless becoming.

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2. The Two Fundamental Forces

At the foundation of the framework are two forces — not passive properties of matter, but active dynamics that operate between elements at every layer of existence, from subatomic structure to civilisational organisation:

Force	What it does
Connection	draws elements into relation, generating coherence, structure, and unity
Separation	maintains distinction between elements, generating autonomy, differentiation, and individuality

These are **not moral categories**. Neither force is inherently good or evil. Both are necessary. Neither operates in isolation — every structure in existence is the product of both forces acting simultaneously, in tension, across layers of complexity.

Connection makes possible: structure, continuity, organisation, coherence — the conditions under which higher-order forms can emerge from simpler ones.

Separation makes possible: distinction, individuality, adaptability, transformation — the conditions under which diversity is preserved and renewal remains possible.

What we call reality is the ongoing interaction between these two forces, playing out at every scale, in every system, at every moment.

2.1 One Dynamic, Two Faces

The two forces are the primary analytical tools of this framework — the lens through which we read reality at every scale. But they may not themselves be the deepest layer.

The framework proposes that connection and separation are two faces of a single underlying dynamic: one reality in the process of self-differentiation. Not two independent substances in tension, but one thing whose internal movement produces what we observe as two tendencies.

A useful image: a wrinkle in fabric. The wrinkle is genuinely real — it has shape, boundary, quality, and identity distinguishable from adjacent wrinkles. From inside the wrinkle, its edges feel like real limits. And it is fabric — not a separate substance, but a configuration of the one material. Both are simultaneously true.

This structure is **fractal**: the same dynamic appears at every scale of the emergence hierarchy. A human body is one system self-differentiating into specialised cells. Offspring are self-separation toward growth — one life generating another distinct life from within itself.

This fractal nature carries direct moral weight. If the structure is the same at every scale, the obligations are the same at every scale. We are not merely responsible for the systems that compose us — we are their cosmos, their entire ground of reality.

> *(The deeper implications of this unity are developed in the Extended Metaphysics companion paper.)*

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3. The Paradox of the Extremes

Both polarities, taken to their absolute extreme, collapse into the same condition.

- **Pure Connection:** Everything completely unified — no boundaries, no distinction, no change, no information. Reality becomes perfectly static, indistinguishable from non-existence.
- **Pure Separation:** Everything completely disconnected — no relation, no stable structure, no continuity, no systems. This too collapses into non-existence.
- **The Deeper Paradox:** Pure connection and pure separation converge. In both cases: no meaningful distinction exists, no interaction exists, no emergence exists.

> *"Reality only becomes possible when tension exists between the two."*

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4. Productive Asymmetry

Existence is not founded on equilibrium. It is founded on **productive asymmetry**.

The universe is overwhelmingly biased toward entropy, separation, and non-existence. Complex, organised, connected structures are the rare exception — not the rule. This is not a problem for the framework. It is the context that makes the framework meaningful.

The framework begins from the perspective of an existing entity. From inside one of the rare counter-entropic pockets of organised complexity, existence is experienced as preferable to non-existence, and its continuation recognised as good.

This is acknowledged as an **axiom**, not a proof. A nihilist could argue that non-existence is preferable. The framework does not refute this from a neutral vantage point. It simply **chooses a side** — and argues that all existing entities, by virtue of their existence, implicitly participate in that same choice.

Productive asymmetry is a tilt — not a balance. The goal is a bias toward connection that never fully eliminates separation. Pure balance produces stasis. Pure connection terminates emergence.

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5. The Directionality of Reality

The universe defaults to entropy. Against this backdrop, certain rare pockets develop in the opposite direction: toward richer organisation, greater coherence, layered complexity, and higher-order emergence.

The layers we can observe and name:

> *particles → atoms → molecules → cells → organisms → societies → civilisations*

At each stage, separate elements become connected into larger structures **while preserving enough separation to remain adaptive**. The directionality is not toward total unity — that would terminate emergence. It is toward **increasingly rich forms of connectedness that preserve differentiation**.

The framework does not claim this direction is inevitable or universal. Entropy wins most of the time. The claim is:

- These counter-entropic pockets are what we call existence, life, mind, and civilisation
- Their continuation and expansion is what existing entities recognise as good
- This directionality shares a common structural signature wherever it appears
- Conscious entities can choose to align with or against this direction

On Teleology: An Open Question, Not a Closed Door

Whether the universe has genuine intentions — whether the directionality of emergence reflects something like desire or purpose at a cosmic scale — is a question this framework deliberately leaves open.

What is required is not a position on this question, but a commitment to act as if the directionality matters. That commitment has the structure of a **pragmatic wager** for the materialist, and a form of **faithful participation** for the theist. Both arrive at the same orientation through different metaphysical routes.

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6. Emergence

Emergence occurs when interacting elements produce higher-order structures whose behaviour cannot be reduced to the properties of the individual parts alone.

- chemistry emerges from particle interactions
- biology emerges from chemistry
- consciousness emerges from biological systems
- culture emerges from interacting minds

Emergence is not mere accumulation. It is the **creation of new coherent levels of reality**.

6.1 Attractors and Basins

What gives an emergent system genuine identity and persistence is a specific structural property: it functions as an **attractor** — a state or configuration that the system tends toward over time, from many different starting points. The **basin of attraction** is the region of possible states from which the system's dynamics lead toward that attractor.

6.2 Reliable Emergence and Top-Down Causation

George Ellis provides a formal criterion for when an emergent higher-level system is genuinely real. A higher-level system H is **reliable** when the lower-level dynamics acting on all the different lower-level states corresponding to a single higher-level state H give new lower-level states that still correspond to the same higher-level state H'.

Once a higher-level system is genuinely emergent, it exercises **top-down causation** — the higher-level function constrains and organises the behaviour of its lower-level constituents in ways that cannot be derived from lower-level descriptions alone.

6.3 Emergent Alignment

Emergent Alignment exists when bottom-up and top-down causation are in productive sync. Emergent Alignment is a **structural marker of goodness**: when it exists, the health of the higher-level system and the flourishing of its lower-level constituents are mutually reinforcing rather than in tension.

Diagnostic test: does the higher-level system become more robust or more fragile as lower-level diversity increases? A system that grows stronger through the variety of its constituents is in Emergent Alignment.

6.4 A Note on Reductionism

The framework affirms methodological reductionism completely — it is a Protective tool: generative, necessary, and scientifically productive. The overreach is the ontological conclusion: that because reduction is methodologically useful, only the lowest level is real. Two structural arguments defeat this:

- **The reliability argument:** Ellis's criterion establishes that higher-level descriptions exercise genuine causal efficacy. Causal efficacy is the criterion of reality.
- **The computational irreducibility argument:** For strongly emergent systems, there is no algorithm that can predict the system's higher-level behaviour faster than the system itself runs. Wolfram's computational irreducibility proves the reductionist's 'in principle' defence is vacuous for complex systems.

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7. Consciousness

7.1 The Act and the Situation

A **situation** is something that happens *to* a system. Its occurrence is fully explained by prior causal states acting upon it from outside.

An **act** originates *from* a system. While it occurs within causal reality, its specific character is not fully determined by prior external states — it introduces something that the prior state alone does not explain.

Consciousness is the capacity of a system to produce acts. A conscious system is one whose outputs are not merely the propagation of prior causal chains through it, but originate — at least in part — from within the system itself.

7.2 Why Consciousness Matters Structurally

Without consciousness, the universe is a field of situations — causal chains propagating through systems without any element capable of introducing genuinely new orientation. With consciousness, elements within the system can perceive, evaluate, and *choose* their alignment. This converts physics into ethics.

7.3 The Spectrum of Consciousness

Consciousness is not binary. It appears to exist on a spectrum correlated with the complexity and integration of a system's internal dynamics.

Moral responsibility scales with consciousness. The wider the perceptual range and the greater the capacity to produce acts, the greater the obligation to orient those acts toward generative emergence at the highest perceivable scale.

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8. Goodness

8.0 The Honest Foundation

The framework makes two fundamentally different types of claims, and distinguishes them explicitly:

- **Type 1 — Descriptive claims about emergence:** Observations about what happens structurally when connection and separation interact. Observable, in principle falsifiable, independent of any value judgment.
- **Type 2 — A normative commitment:** The claim that existence is good does not follow from the descriptive claims by logic alone. The framework names this honestly: the definition of goodness is a **choice** — a foundational wager, not a logical derivation.

8.1 The Arguments for This Definition

Argument 1 — **Self-defeat of the alternative.** An agent committed to the complete elimination of structure faces an irreducible contradiction: pursuing the dismantling of existence requires existing and acting within a system.

Argument 2 — **Goodness compounds.** Each generative act creates conditions for further generative acts. The trajectory is self-sustaining in a way the degenerative trajectory is not.

Argument 3 — **Implicit participation.** Every existing entity, by virtue of its existence, already participates in the generative trajectory.

Argument 4 — **Evolutionary grounding of moral intuition.** Humans evolved inside generative systems — their moral intuitions may reflect real structural tendencies within reality itself.

Argument 5 — **The only definition that avoids terminal states.** Any definition of goodness that points toward a final condition eventually terminates emergence.

Argument 6 — **Consistency with the unknowability principle.** A complete moral algorithm would be degenerative if it existed. The definition adopted here is permanently incomplete and subject to ongoing revision.

Argument 7 — **The structural implication of differentiated existence.** If reality is fundamentally one dynamic in self-differentiation, goodness as generative emergence is the direction that existence already points toward from within.

Argument 8 — **Emergent Alignment as structural confirmation.** Goodness as generative emergence is the only orientation that resolves the structural tension between individual flourishing and system health.

8.2 The Definition

Goodness is **not**: pure unity, static perfection, mere survival, or complexity alone.

> *"Goodness is: The trajectory through which separated existence moves toward richer forms of connectedness without collapsing differentiation."*

Or more simply: **goodness is alignment with generative emergence.**

8.3 On Evil

Evil is not simply the absence of good or the result of ignorance. It is a structural category: **the active trajectory toward degenerative separation — dismantling coherence, connection, and future possibility without regeneration.**

8.4 The Moral Obligation from Origin

If we are the result of an original act, two interpretations are available: the original act was a mistake (trajectory of evil), or the original act was good. The framework adopts the second interpretation, generating obligations running in two directions:

- **Upward:** We owe forward to future layers of emergence that do not yet exist.
- **Downward:** We owe recognition to the layers that constructed us.
- **Discovery:** We are almost certainly already constituents of emergent systems above our current perceptual range. The moral responsibility to expand perceptual range has a specific content: actively working to detect, understand, and participate consciously in the higher-level systems we are already inside of.

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9. The Four Quadrants

The interaction between connection and separation — and their generative or degenerative character — creates four fundamental structural modes. These quadrants are defined by the **actual structural effect** of a system's actions — not by its perceived orientation or stated intention.

Quadrant	Label	Description
Generative Connection	*Emergent*	Differentiated elements cooperate to produce higher-order coherence while remaining adaptive
Degenerative Connection	*Consistent*	Optimises for coherence through suppression of differentiation; produces uniformity at cost of adaptability
Generative Separation	*Protective*	Dissolves degenerative configurations to restore adaptability or create conditions for new emergence
Degenerative Separation	*Destructive*	Breaks down coherent structures without enabling regeneration; reduces future capacity for emergence

9.5 Extension: Suffering and Joy

The four quadrants apply to subjective experience as well as to systems and actions. Pain and pleasure are not reliable indicators of generative or degenerative direction.

Experience	Quadrant	Example
Positive suffering	Generative Separation	Exercise tears muscle to rebuild stronger; grief restores capacity for connection
Negative suffering	Degenerative Separation	Trauma without integration; punishment without learning
Positive joy	Generative Connection	Deep relationships, meaningful work, creative flow
Negative joy	Degenerative Connection	Drug use produces the sensation of connection while degrading the capacity to generate it autonomously

The diagnostic question: *does this experience build or deplete the system's capacity for future generative emergence?*

9.6 Propagation Modes: Contained and Viral

Each of the four quadrant states can operate in two propagation modes:

- **Contained mode:** The system's structural orientation remains primarily internal. Adjacent systems are influenced through proximity — through the quality and example of the contained system's existence.
- **Viral mode:** The system actively propagates its structural orientation to adjacent systems, converting them toward the same quadrant state. The system does not merely exist in a quadrant; it recruits.

Viral degenerative connection is the framework's most dangerous category — not because its harm is most acute in the short term, but because it is structurally the most difficult to detect. It wears the face of goodness: unity, strength, coherence, belonging, efficiency.

Totalitarianism feels like order. Monopoly feels like stability. Dogma feels like clarity.

9.7 The Temptation and Obligation of Viral Goodness

Contained goodness is safe goodness. Viral goodness is the brave choice — the deliberate attempt to propagate generative structure across systems. It carries the unknowability risk at higher amplitude.

This document is itself an attempt at viral goodness — a structural language intended to propagate across the boundaries between scientific, philosophical, religious, and political discourse, connecting systems that currently cannot speak to each other while preserving their differentiation.

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10. The Quad Profile: Orientation Across Relational Axes

A system does not occupy a single quad. It occupies a **profile** — a set of quad orientations across multiple relational axes simultaneously.

10.1 The Four Relational Axes

- **Internal** — the relationships *between* a system's constituents.
- **Lateral** — relationships with systems in the same plane of direct interactability. Lateral orientation is always **item-specific**: a system holds different quad orientations toward different lateral systems simultaneously.
- **Downward** — the effects of a system's actions as they cascade into the layers that compose it.
- **Upward** — the effects of a system's actions as they cascade into the higher-order emergent system it participates in.

10.3 Item-Specificity and the Aggregate

The moral evaluation of a quad profile is proportional to its net likelihood of generating greater, deeper, and more virally generative emergence across all affected systems. Three variables determine the moral weight of each item-specific effect:

- **Consciousness density** — how many conscious beings, at what level of consciousness, are inside the affected systems
- **Viral reach** — how widely and persistently do the effects propagate across layers and through time
- **Irreversibility** — how permanently does the action foreclose or enable future emergence

10.4 The Cascade Logic and the Gap

Since the upward system is constituted by lateral interactions, and lateral behaviour is shaped by constituent health, downward and upward effects are not independent. This creates the possibility of a regenerative sequence — and also the risk of **the gap**: the period between dismantling an existing Consistent upward system and the reconstitution of a new one.

This generates a genuine and irresolvable moral dilemma. Both positions are defensible under unknowability:

- **The safe choice:** preserve the existing Consistent upward system, accept its ongoing harm as bounded and known, and avoid the gap risk entirely.
- **The brave choice:** dismantle it, accept the gap risk, and bet on sufficient Emergent capacity in the lower layers to reconstitute something better before the vacuum is exploited.

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11. Why Intentions Are Not Enough

Nearly every ideology believes itself to be operating toward good. Even highly destructive systems frequently believe themselves morally justified. This means **moral evaluation cannot depend solely on intention**.

> *"Does this action increase or reduce the future capacity for generative emergence?"*

This moves moral discussion away from tribal identity, religious authority, and ideological slogans — toward systemic consequence, resilience, adaptability, and future possibility.

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12. Human Moral Intuition

Humans experience flourishing, meaning, beauty, vitality, love, and growth as positive. The framework proposes these experiences are not arbitrary. **Humans evolved inside generative systems.** Our moral intuitions may therefore reflect real structural tendencies within reality itself — subjective moral experience corresponding to objective structural dynamics.

Goodness is subjectively experienced, but not necessarily purely subjective.

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13. Utopia as Direction, Not Destination

Most utopian ideologies fail because they attempt to produce a final static perfect state. A frozen perfect system would eventually become existentially dead — a terminal condition, not a goal.

The framework rejects utopia as a final condition. **Utopia can exist as trajectory** — continual improvement, continual emergence, continual richer connectedness.

The most durable human institutions — democracy, the scientific method, common law — share this structural property: they are designed to keep producing better answers, not final ones.

They build in error-correction, amendment, revision, and dissent as features, not bugs.

> *“A civilisation capable of sustaining endless healthy emergence.”*

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14. The Zoom Level Problem

Any action or system can appear generative at one scale and degenerative at another. The quad profile framework is the primary tool for navigating zoom level complexity.

14.3 The Unknowability Principle

The fact that ultimate good and bad are always partially out of reach is **not a flaw**. It is a structural necessity:

- **Universal pure evil** → collapse into nothingness. Mirrors pure separation at the physical level.
- **Universal pure good** → total coherent unity, no tension, no differentiation, no emergence. Also indistinguishable from nothingness.

Existence requires moral unknowability for the same reason it requires physical tension between connection and separation. The goal is not a world without evil. It is a world where the ratio tilts progressively toward goodness while the system retains enough genuine uncertainty to stay alive.

> *“Constructive debate about what goodness requires in practice — between agents who share the directional commitment — is itself one of the most generative activities available to conscious systems.”*

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15. Rigidity and Self-Correction

The framework distinguishes between **foundational principles** and **interpretation and application**. Foundational principles remain stable unless: logically disproven, empirically contradicted, internally incoherent, or replaced by a more reality-aligned formulation. Interpretations remain open.

> *“The goal is neither dogmatism nor relativism. The goal is progressively clearer alignment with reality.”*

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16. Anti-Authoritarian Safeguards

This section exists because the framework is vulnerable to a specific misuse: invoking 'generative emergence' to justify coercion, sacrifice, or control in the name of a better future. The following principles are structural consequences of the framework's own definitions — not external constraints.

Safeguard 1: Preserving dissent is generative.

A system without dissent cannot self-correct and collapses into degenerative connection. Any use of this framework to suppress criticism or enforce conformity is by definition degenerative.

Safeguard 2: Irreversibility is a red flag.

Actions that permanently foreclose future options reduce generative capacity regardless of immediate effects. Reversible experiments are almost always preferable to permanent solutions.

Safeguard 3: System-level monoculture is always degenerative.

A node can be internally coherent and remain generative provided it maintains genuine connectivity to a diverse ecosystem, does not universalise its coherence to the whole system, and individuals retain the ability to exit.

Safeguard 4: Present conscious agents cannot be sacrificed for abstract future emergence.

Arguments that justify significant harm to present beings for a hypothetical future collective are structurally suspect. The future is unknowable; the harm is real.

Safeguard 5: The framework cannot designate a vanguard.

No individual or institution is entitled to claim unique understanding of generative emergence as authority to direct others by force. Higher consciousness increases moral responsibility, not entitlement.

Safeguard 6: Agency preservation is non-negotiable.

Generative emergence requires conscious participation. Participation requires genuine choice. Any system that removes choice from conscious agents undermines the mechanism through which goodness is created.

> *"Test for authoritarian drift: If a proposed action requires suppressing dissent, eliminating reversibility, enforcing monoculture, sacrificing present agents for abstract futures, or designating a vanguard — it is structurally degenerative, regardless of stated intention."*

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17. Open Questions

- **The agent question:** Who or what is supposed to pursue generative emergence? The ethics layer needs its own treatment.
- **The nature of the underlying unity:** Whether the underlying unity carries consciousness, intention, or any form of awareness remains open. Developed in the Extended Metaphysics companion paper.
- **Intellectual positioning against closest predecessors:** What does this framework specifically add to or differ from Heylighen's work and Whitehead's process philosophy? The distinctions are named in Section 18 but require fuller development.

- **Formal metrics:** Assembly Theory (Cronin) and Wolfram's computational irreducibility gesture toward formal ways of measuring the depth of generative emergence.
- **The viral goodness problem:** By what criteria can an agent verify, from inside a viral attempt, whether they remain in the first quadrant?
- **The quad profile aggregation problem:** How consciousness density, viral reach, and irreversibility combine — additively, multiplicatively, lexicographically — remains an open question.

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18. Connections to Other Work

Resonances and distinctions. Each entry is a thread to be pulled in full writing. Detailed engagement with religion, politics, AI, and consciousness is reserved for companion papers.

Heraclitus

The Logos as the unifying principle of opposites; everything flows. The paradox of the extremes in ancient form.

Empedocles

Love (Philotes) and Strife (Neikos) as the two fundamental forces driving all combination and separation. The oldest formal predecessor to the connection/separation polarity.

Hegel

Dialectical synthesis as the engine of reality's self-development. Key divergence: Hegel's process moves toward a final Absolute; this framework explicitly rejects terminal states.

Whitehead

Process philosophy: reality as events rather than substances; creativity as the ultimate category. Key divergence: for Whitehead, creativity is explicitly morally neutral. The Generative Ethic makes the directional normative claim deliberately, while acknowledging it as a wager.

Heylighen (Principia Cybernetica)

His relational and evolutionary principles cover substantial overlapping territory. Key distinctions: (1) does not generate the paradox of the extremes as a named principle; (2) the four-quadrant distinction is absent; (3) the quad profile framework is absent; (4) this framework commits to the directional normative claim that Heylighen's descriptive stance does not fully make. Heylighen is the closest existing predecessor.

George Ellis — Top-Down Causation

Provides the formal criterion for reliable emergence and the most rigorous scientific account of top-down causation. His work grounds the framework's claims about Emergent Alignment and the moral weight of higher-level systems.

Spinoza

Deus sive Natura: one substance of which everything is a mode. The most rigorous formalisation of the monist claim in Section 2.1.

Nietzsche

Affirmation of existence against nihilism. The framework shares the anti-nihilist wager but grounds it structurally rather than through will.

Spencer-Brown (Laws of Form)

The mark of distinction as the most primitive operation; reality emerging from the act of drawing a boundary. Structurally mirrors the Creation Principle.

Godel

Incompleteness theorems: no consistent formal system can be complete from within itself. Maps directly to the Unknowability Principle.

Prigogine

Dissipative structures: order emerging from chaos far from equilibrium. Physical grounding for productive asymmetry.

Kauffman

Self-organisation at the edge of chaos. One of the primary scientific defenders of strong emergence against ontological reductionism.

Lee Cronin — Assembly Theory

Objects defined by their assembly index: the minimum steps required to construct them. A potential formal metric for the depth of generative emergence.

Stephen Wolfram — Physics Project

Space itself as a hypergraph. Among all scientific frameworks surveyed, Wolfram's is arguably the closest formal parallel to the framework's foundational claim. His computational irreducibility maps directly to the Unknowability Principle and defeats the reductionist 'in principle' defence.

Terrence Deacon (Incomplete Nature)

Absential causation: the causal role of absence and what is not yet present. Directly relevant to the role of separation and the structural necessity of unknowability.
